Department of Management Studies

Indian Institute of Technology, Delhi

Executive Programme in Brand Management

Capstone project: Case Study on
"Sanfe — Revolutionizing Feminine Hygiene and Empowering Women"

CASE STUDY: Sanfe — Revolutionizing Feminine Hygiene and Empowering Women

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Abstract

Sanfe, a sanitation startup incubated at IIT Delhi, is a pioneering venture addressing women's health and wellness needs. By introducing innovative solutions like the Stand-and-Pee kit, Sanfe has disrupted the hygiene industry while advocating for behavioural change and empowerment. This case study explores the company's journey from inception to achieving profitability, detailing its product innovations, marketing strategies, and solutions for market challenges. By breaking taboos and promoting sustainability, Sanfe has become a transformational player in the personal care sector. Sanfe has achieved rapid growth by tapping into unmet needs and fostering behavioural change.

This case study delves into the company's journey, examining its product innovations, growth strategies, efforts to promote awareness and empowerment, commitment to sustainabilit1y, and the insights it offers for the broader feminine hygiene market

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Introduction

Sanfe, short for "Sanitation for Females," is a women's health care and wellness brand designed to address the hygiene issues associated with public restrooms. Founded in 2018 by IIT Delhi students Archit Aggarwal and Harry Sehrawat, Sanfe emerged as a solution to the alarming number of urinary tract infections (UTIs) caused by unsanitary toilet seats. Research shows that over 50% of women suffer from UTIs at least once in their lifetime, a statistic that inspired Sanfe's flagship product: the Stand-and-Pee kit.

Designed with a biodegradable material and a one-handed grip, the Stand-and-Pee kit is ideal for pregnant women, elderly individuals, and those with mobility challenges. Sanfe's products prioritize convenience, hygiene, and sustainability, making it a revolutionary brand in the Indian personal care market.

Background of the organization and Brand Founders

Sanfe (Redroom Technology Private Limited) was co-founded by Archit Aggarwal and Harry Sehrawat, both engineering students at IIT Delhi. Their motivation stemmed from a college trip where they witnessed the repercussions of unsanitary public toilets firsthand. Together, they developed a simple yet innovative solution that laid the foundation for their startup journey.

Mission and Vision

- **Mission**: To empower women with innovative and sustainable hygiene solutions while fostering behavioral change and awareness.
- **Vision**: To become a global leader in feminine hygiene by addressing unmet needs and breaking taboos.

Key Milestones

- **2018**: Launch of Sanfe with its flagship product, the Stand-and-Pee kit.
- **2019**: Expanded product offerings to include menstrual cups and intimate washes.
- **2020**: Secured seed funding and achieved nationwide presence through online platforms.
- **2019-2023**: Partnered with NGOs to expand rural outreach, targeting over 1 million beneficiaries.
- **2024:** Attained an ARR of ₹300 crores by the end of October 2024, marking sixfold revenue growth.

Market Analysis: Size, Competition and Challenges

Metrics of Success:

April- May 2024

Sales Growth: Sanfe has consistently achieved double-digit growth in sales, with reports suggesting a 40% increase in revenues year over year (2022-2023).

Customer Acquisition: The brand saw a 35% increase in repeat customers, indicating a strong brand loyalty base among consumers.

Average Sales/Day on D2C Website: The growth in Sanfe's Direct-to-Consumer (D2C) sales via its website has been impressive. Here is a breakdown of average sales per day (as of each year):

- 2020: ₹5,000/day
- 2021: ₹30,000/day
- 2022: ₹3,00,000/day
- 2023: ₹8,00,000/day
- 2024: ₹17,00,000/day

This rapid increase in daily sales demonstrates the growing consumer confidence and trust in the Sanfe brand, reflecting both the increasing demand for its products and the success of its e-commerce strategy.

Quick Commerce Growth: Sanfe has been aggressive in its growth on quick commerce platforms like Blinkit and Zepto, reflecting the increasing demand for fast delivery and convenience in urban markets. In FY 2024-25, Sanfe initially aimed for an Annual Recurring Revenue (ARR) of ₹50 crores through Blinkit.

However, the brand exceeded expectations, achieving an impressive ₹60 crores ARR in just 3 months.

End of Oct 2024:

Revenue Growth: Sanfe grew from ₹50 crore ARR (Annual Recurring Revenue) to ₹300 crores in one year (2023-24), marking a Growth. (6x).

Next Goal: The next revenue target is ₹1000 crores ARR.
EBITDA: The Brand maintained an EBITDA of 15% during this period.

How Sanfe achieved this growth

Sanfe's remarkable growth trajectory can be attributed to its strategic initiatives and innovative approaches:

1. Identifying a Market Gap

The intimate hygiene market in India is projected to grow at a CAGR of 14% from 2022 to 2027, driven by the growing awareness of health and hygiene among women. The founders recognized the lack of hygienic solutions for women, particularly in public restrooms. This insight allowed Sanfe to position itself as a problem-solver, targeting a niche market that had been overlooked by larger brands.

2. Product Innovation

Sanfe's commitment to innovation led to the creation of products like:

- **Stand-and-Pee Kit**: A portable, biodegradable solution to address UTI risks.
- **Glycoclear technology** - Breakthrough innovation launched by the brand. From gentle exfoliation to pore purification and surface renewal, GlycoClear Complex technology tackles multiple skin concerns with precision and effectiveness.

- **Menstrual Roll-On**: An innovative pain relief product that gained rapid popularity.
- **Reusable Menstrual Cups**: Promoting sustainability alongside hygiene. Each product was developed after extensive user feedback and went through multiple design iterations to ensure effectiveness and usability.
- **Intimate washes:** Offering pH balanced solutions for daily hygiene needs.

Fixative Beauty Products:

- Glutathione Soap and Lotion
- Sanfe Next Day Glass Skin Mask
- Teeth whitening strips
- Instant Tan Removal Cream

3. Quick Commerce: Sanfe has seen huge growth in the quick commerce segment, leveraging platforms like Blinkit and Zepto to cater to the growing demand for rapid delivery and convenience in urban markets. Originally targeting an Annual Recurring Revenue (ARR) of ₹50 crores through Blinkit in FY 2024-25, Sanfe shattered expectations, achieving an incredible Rs 60 crores ARR within just three months having a Customer Acquisition Cost (CAC) of ₹60. This remarkable growth reflects the brand's adaptability and strong consumer demand in the fast-paced world of quick commerce.

4**. E-Commerce Dominance**

Sanfe leveraged online platforms like Amazon, Flipkart, and Nykaa to reach a wider audience. Its direct-to-consumer (D2C) website has also contributed significantly to revenue.

5**. Offline Presence**

- Sanfe has expanded its reach beyond online platforms to strengthen the brand's presence in the physical world.
- Expanded into new channels such as General Trade & Modern Trade.
- Apollo Pharmacy: Sanfe's products are available in Apollo Pharmacy outlets, helping the brand reach a broader audience, including customers who prefer in-store shopping for personal care products.

6**. Affordable Pricing**

By ensuring competitive pricing, Sanfe made its products accessible to a broad demographic. Promotional discounts and offers encouraged first-time purchases, driving customer acquisition.

For example, Sanfe invested in local manufacturing for sheet masks, which were previously imported from China/Korea. Sanfe launched these at ₹49 exclusively on Blinkit, and in just 5 days, we reached 500 units per day, making it the fastest-growing SKU on Blinkit.

7**. Strategic Marketing**

Sanfe's marketing campaigns played a pivotal role in driving growth:

- **Social Media Campaigns**: Campaigns like #RedDot and #StandUpForYourself 50created widespread awareness and engagement.
- **Influencer Collaborations**: Partnered with health influencers to build credibility and reach younger audiences.
- **Educational Drives**: Conducted over 500 workshops in schools, colleges, and rural areas to educate women about hygiene. These strategies not only increased brand visibility but also fostered trust among consumers.

8. Content Strategy: Creating extensive content centred on women's wellness and empowerment, complemented by engaging user-generated content on Instagram.

9. Brand Collaborations and Giveaways:

In addition to social media campaigns, Sanfe also engaged in strategic brand collaborations and giveaways to further enhance its brand visibility and customer engagement:

• Sanfe x Zepto: A promotional collaboration where users who purchased Sanfe products between August 17th-19th were entered into a giveaway to win an iPhone.

• Sanfe x Rennie: A collaboration offering Rennie's perfume on purchases above ₹1200.

• Sanfe x FreeCultr: A Valentine's Day giveaway encouraging users to share their celebration plans for a chance to win prizes worth ₹3000.

10. Strong Funding Support

Sanfe secured seed funding from IIT Delhi's incubation program and additional investments from organizations like Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Limited (HPCL), Seeders and Yukti Securities with other investors. This financial backing enabled the startup to develop innovative solutions for women's health and hygiene.

- Product development and scaling.
- Expansion of distribution channels.
- Investments in marketing and branding.

11. Expanding Product Portfolio

Diversification played a critical role in sustaining growth. Sanfe expanded its range to include menstrual cups, intimate washes, deodorants, and grooming products. This approach allowed the brand to cater to a wider audience while retaining existing customers.

12. Rural Outreach Initiatives

Understanding the untapped potential in rural markets, Sanfe:

- Sanfe partnered with NGOs such as Sachi Saheli, Spherule Foundation, Pinkishe, and CWEI to distribute free samples and conduct awareness programs. The initiative focused on rural outreach, distributing reusable sanitary pads that are 100% biodegradable and made of composite banana fiber.
- Collaborated with government initiatives to improve access to hygiene products. These efforts helped Sanfe penetrate underserved areas, driving both social impact and business growth.
- Focused on Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities through NGO partnerships and conducted numerous workshops.

13. Sustainability Focus

Sanfe's emphasis on eco-friendly materials and reusable products resonated with environmentally conscious consumers. This commitment to sustainability not only differentiated the brand but also fostered long-term customer loyalty.

14. Building Customer Trust

Sanfe prioritized transparency in its communication, offering clear instructions on product use and emphasizing safety. The inclusion of educational inserts in packaging further strengthened customer relationships.

15. Branding Approach

Sanfe's branding emphasizes trust, transparency, and empowerment:

- **Empowering Messaging:** Campaigns are centered around empowering women to prioritize their health without hesitation.
- **Sustainability Focus:** By championing biodegradable and reusable products, Sanfe appeals to environmentally conscious consumers.
- **Community Building:** Sanfe partnered with NGOs to raise hygiene awareness and distribute free products and educated over 1 million women through 500 outreach programs.

Competition Analysis:

CATEGORY	PEESAFE	NUA	SIRONA
FOUNDED YEAR	2013	2016	2015
TOTAL RAISED	$12.66M	$18.3M	$16.64M
FOCUS AREA	Personal hygiene products	Organic female hygiene products	Menstrual and intimate hygiene products
KEY PRODUCTS	Toilet seat sanitizers, menstrual cups, intimate washes, sanitary pads,	Organic sanitary pads, self-heating patches, acne patches, face wash	Tampons, sanitary pads, menstrual cups, intimate hygiene products

FOCUSING ON BRANDING, STRATEGY AND MARKETING:

CATEGORY	PEE SAFE	NUA	SIRONA
BRANDING	Strong branding around personal hygiene and wellness for all genders	Organic, rash-free, and customizable hygiene solutions with a premium feel	Affordable and quality feminine hygiene products focused on redefining femininity.
STRATEGY	Broad product range, focusing on convenience and personal hygiene innovation	Subscription-based model with personalized packs and frequency.	Wide product range and affordability while addressing hygiene education gaps.
MARKETING	Strong e-commerce presence with partnerships on major platforms and influencer promotions	Focused digital marketing, including Instagram campaigns and eco-conscious messaging.	Relies on education-driven marketing and campaigns targeting health-conscious women.

SWOT Analysis:

Strengths: Growth potential in a niche market and Sustainable product line with strong brand identity and social impact.

Weaknesses: Limited diversification and Over reliance on e-commerce channels.

Opportunities: Rural penetration and Govt/NGO collaborations.

Threats: Competition from established brands and startups, as well as Stigmas limiting growth.

Marketing Mix–The 4P's

Product: Sanfe's offerings include the Stand-and-Pee kit, menstrual roll-ons, reusable menstrual cups, intimate washes, and grooming products.

Price: Affordable pricing strategies ensure accessibility across demographics. Seasonal promotions and discounts drive customer acquisition.

Place: Sanfe leverages e-commerce platforms like Amazon, Nykaa, and Flipkart alongside offline availability in Apollo Pharmacy outlets.

Promotion: Campaigns like #RedDot and #StandUpForYourself normalized conversations about hygiene and Influencer partnerships and educational workshops increased brand visibility and trust.

Segmentation, Targeting, and Positioning (STP)

1. **Segmentation:**
   - **Demographic Segments:** Women aged 18-45, focusing on students, professionals, and homemakers.
   - **Geographic Segments:** Urban, semi-urban, and rural regions, with targeted campaigns for each demographic.
   - **Behavioural Segments:** Health-conscious consumers, eco-friendly buyers, and frequent travellers.
   - **Psychographic Segmentation**: Focuses on women who emphasize personal well-being and seek trustworthy, budget-friendly personal care options.
2. **Targeting:**
   - Focused on urban professionals and college students who are digitally savvy and open to innovative solutions.
   - Expanded outreach to rural women through NGO collaborations and affordable product lines.
   - Targets women who prioritize hygiene products that are safe, affordable and readily accessible.

3. **Positioning:**
    - Sanfe positions itself as a “trusted ally” in women’s hygiene, emphasizing sustainability, innovation, and empowerment.
    - Branding focuses on addressing unmet needs while normalizing conversations about hygiene.
    - Offering women a comprehensive platform to address all their needs, from intimate hygiene, menstrual care to fixative skincare solutions.

Branding Framework

Sanfe’s branding is built on the following pillars:

1. **Core Identity:**
    - Empowering women through sustainable and effective hygiene solutions.
    - A commitment to breaking taboos and driving social change.
2. **Visual and Verbal Identity:**
    - **Name:** Sanfe stands for "Sanitation for Females," aiming to provide women with hygienic and empowering solutions.
    - Vibrant packaging with eco-conscious designs.
    - **Tonality:** Empathetic, empowering and educational. Through its communication, Sanfe encourages women to prioritize their health and wellbeing.
    - **Logo:** Simple yet bold purple design, reflecting trust and empowerment.
3. **Emotional Connection:**
    - Campaigns like #RedDot fostered solidarity among women and normalized discussions about menstruation.
    - Partnerships with influencers and celebrities enhanced credibility and trust.
    - Builds an emotional connection with its audience through interactive Instagram stories, encouraging women to share their experiences, fostering a supportive space where they feel heard and valued.

- Thoughtful live sessions and webinars on Instagram with healthcare professionals, offering women a safe environment to engage in conversations and gain essential health insights with confidence.

4. **Brand Availability and Visibility:**
    - Omni-channel presence across e-commerce, quick commerce, and modern trade.
    - Active social media campaigns ensure constant engagement with consumers.
5. **Brand Recognition:**
    - Sanfe's consistent branding efforts have led to high recall value in the feminine hygiene sector.
    - Recognized for its innovative products and eco-friendly approach.

Social Media Presence

Sanfe has effectively utilized social media as a core pillar of its marketing strategy. By leveraging platforms like Instagram, Facebook, and YouTube, the brand has created a vibrant and engaging digital presence:

- **Notable Campaigns**:

- **#RedDot**: Aimed at normalizing menstruation, generating over 2 million impressions.
- **#StandUpForYourself**: Focused on empowering women to adopt better hygiene practices, engaging with over 1 lakh users.
- **#ChooseToChallenge:** Launched in celebration of Women's Day, the campaign encouraged women to challenge stereotypes, address inequality, and celebrate their achievements, while also promoting empowerment and hygiene.

1. Instagram Content

- **Content Focus**: Instagram is a key platform for Sanfe, featuring a mix of educational content, user testimonials, interactive stories as well as visually appealing product imagery. User generated content (UGC) has worked effectively for Sanfe.
- **Collaborations**: partnered with influencers in health, fitness, and eco-conscious sectors, as well as health professionals, to educate women through live sessions and webinars.

2. Facebook Engagement

- **Awareness Drives**: Hosted live sessions with gynaecologists and health experts to discuss women's hygiene issues.
- **User Interaction**: Engaged actively with customers through comments, messages, and community groups.
- **Campaign Performance**: Achieved a reach of 5 million users through targeted ad campaigns.

3. YouTube Videos

- **Educational Content**: Created videos explaining product usage, benefits, and hygiene tips.
- **Impact Stories**: Showcased testimonials from rural women and urban professionals, highlighting how Sanfe products improved their lives.
- **Metrics**: Over 1 million cumulative views across videos.

4. Twitter Advocacy

- **Real-Time Engagement**: Used Twitter to address queries, share campaign updates, and participate in trending discussions related to hygiene and women's empowerment.
- **Hashtag Campaigns**: Promoted hashtags like #SustainablePeriods and #HygieneForAll to drive conversations.

5. Data-Driven Insights

Sanfe uses analytics tools to:

- Monitor engagement rates and refine content strategies.
- Identify trending topics and incorporate them into campaigns.
- Track ROI on paid ads, ensuring efficient allocation of resources.

Buyer Behaviour Insights

Sanfe's target audience demonstrates unique behavioral patterns driven by their specific hygiene needs:

1. **Health Consciousness**: Increasing awareness about hygiene and UTI prevention has made women more receptive to innovative products.
2. **Preference for Convenience**: Urban women seek portable, easy-to-use products that cater to their on-the-go lifestyle.

3. **Sustainability Concerns**: Eco-conscious consumers prioritize biodegradable and reusable products.
4. **Digital Savviness**: A significant portion of Sanfe's buyers are active on e-commerce platforms and influenced by online reviews and social media.
5. **Price Sensitivity**: While open to trying new products, many buyers prefer affordable options.

Buyer Persona

Persona 1: The Urban Professional

- **Age**: 25-35
- **Occupation**: Corporate employee or entrepreneur
- **Pain Points**: Lack of access to clean restrooms during travel and work.
- **Motivations**: Seeks products that combine hygiene, convenience, and sustainability.
- **Preferred Channels**: Online marketplaces like Amazon and Nykaa, social media campaigns.

Persona 2: The College Student

- **Age**: 18-24
- **Occupation**: Undergraduate or postgraduate student
- **Pain Points**: Limited access to sanitary facilities on campus.
- **Motivations**: Attracted to affordable, innovative products marketed through digital campaigns.
- **Preferred Channels**: Instagram ads, Facebook, D2C Website and Google ads.

Persona 3: The Eco-Conscious Mother

- **Age**: 30-45
- **Occupation**: Homemaker or working women.
- **Pain Points**: Concerned about the health and hygiene of her family.
- **Motivations**: Prioritizes sustainability and safety for her household.
- **Preferred Channels**: Offline stores, NGO recommendations, community programs.

Innovation and Product Development

Problem Identification

Sanfe's founders identified a gap in the market for hygienic and portable solutions tailored to women's needs. Public restrooms, especially in India, often lack cleanliness, creating a breeding ground for infections. Studies revealed that 1 in 2 women suffer from UTIs, primarily due to unsanitary toilet conditions.

While traditional feminine hygiene brands like Whisper and Stayfree focus mainly on menstrual care, Sanfe innovated by identifying the need for portable, hygienic solutions for public restrooms. With products like the Stand-and-Pee kit, Sanfe filled a gap that was largely ignored by larger players, positioning itself as a pioneer in this niche market.

Product Portfolio and Innovation

Sanfe's journey began with the Stand-and-Pee kit, a biodegradable, portable urination aid that became a game-changer for women in public spaces. The success of this product laid the foundation for a diversified portfolio:

• Stand-and-Pee Kit (2019): Achieved sales of 2.5 lakh units in its first year.

• Menstrual Roll-On: Sold 25,000 units within just one month of its debut.

1. Period Care:
    - Reusable menstrual cups.
    - Biodegradable sanitary pads and tampons.
    - Menstrual roll-on for pain relief.
    - Reusable sanitary pads made from composite banana fiber
2. Intimate Hygiene:
    - pH-balanced intimate washes.
    - Deodorants and wipes.
3. Body Care:
    - Stretch mark oils and bikini line razors.
    - Daily grooming kits.

Sanfe's emphasis on user feedback and rapid new product development (NPD) has been pivotal. Collaborating closely with suppliers enabled faster launches of high-demand products, reinforcing the brand's adaptability.

The Stand-and-Pee kit underwent 23 iterations before arriving at the final design. Key features include:

- **Biodegradable Material**: Ensures eco-friendliness.

- **Ergonomic Design**: Enables easy one-handed use, accommodating traditional Indian attire.

- **Compact and Travel-Friendly**: Fits seamlessly into handbags for convenience.

Behavioural Change and Awareness Campaigns

Challenges in Behavioural Change

Sanfe faced resistance due to deep-rooted taboos surrounding intimate hygiene. Women were hesitant to adopt new products, viewing them as unnecessary or embarrassing.

Strategies for Change

1. **#StandUpForYourself Campaign**:
    - Offered free samples to women who shared their posts online.
    - Encouraged users to speak about hygiene openly.
2. **#chooseToChange Campaign**
    -Women posted pictures with their hand up, tagged @sanfeofficial, and got featured on the website, with a chance to win gifts.

    - The campaign encouraged women to challenge stereotypes, promote hygiene, and celebrate empowerment.
3. **Workshops and Outreach Programs**:
    - Collaborated with NGOs to conduct over 500 workshops in rural areas.
    - Educated women about the health risks of poor sanitation practices.
4. **Celebrity Endorsements**:
    - Partnered with influencers and celebrities to amplify brand visibility and credibility.
5. **Live sessions and Webinars:** hosted on Instagram with Doctors, gynaecologists and hygiene professionals to educate women about health and hygiene practices.

Impact

- Increased adoption rates by 40% within the first year of launching campaigns.
- Garnered over 2 million impressions on social media, creating widespread awareness.

Future Outlook

Sanfe is poised to revolutionize personal care and hygiene with its innovative tech-based solutions. As a trailblazer in breaking taboos around menstrual and intimate hygiene, Sanfe envisions a future where personal care is synonymous with empowerment, sustainability, and inclusivity. Sanfe's growth strategy involves:

1. **Product Diversification**: Expanding into maternity care and daily-use hygiene essentials.
2. **Rural Penetration**: Leveraging government partnerships to reach underprivileged communities. Deepening rural penetration through partnerships with NGOs and government initiatives.
3. **Technology Integration**: Introducing AI-driven e-commerce tools to enhance customer experience.
4. **Expansion:** Scaling to ₹3 crore/day sales by expanding into new categories like maternity care.
5. **International Expansion**: Sanfe could explore international markets, especially in countries where feminine hygiene awareness is increasing. Countries in Southeast Asia, the Middle East, and Europe could be potential targets due to rising awareness of women's health issues.
6. **Collaboration with healthcare providers:** Collaborating with hospitals, clinics, and health organizations to promote Sanfe's products.

Conclusion

Sanfe's journey exemplifies how innovation, agility, and a deep understanding of consumer needs can transform an industry. By addressing pressing hygiene challenges and fostering social change, Sanfe has positioned itself as a leader in the feminine hygiene market while contributing to a healthier, more empowered society. Its success story is not just a testament to its products but also to its mission of building a better world for women.